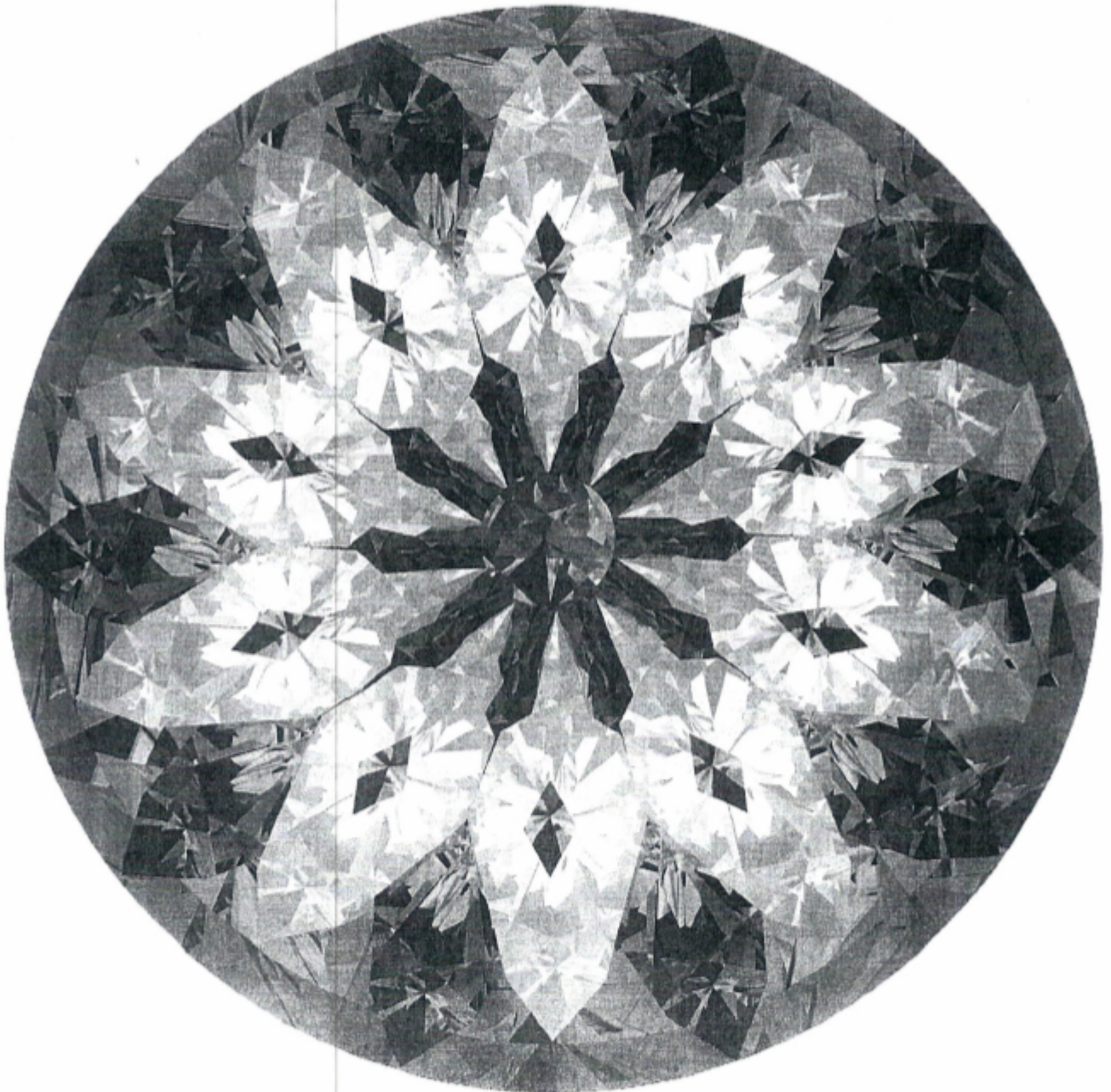


KALEIDOSCOPE

2015



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noun (pl.histories)

1 [mass noun] the study of past events, particularly in human affairs: *medieval European history*.

• the past considered as a whole: *letters that have changed the course of history*.

2 the whole series of past events connected with a particular person or thing: *the history of the Empire* | *a patient with a complicated medical history*.

• an eventful past: *the group has quite a history*.

• a past characterized by a particular thing: *his family had a history of insanity*.

3 a continuous, typically chronological, record of important or public events or of a particular trend or institution: *a history of the labour movement*.

• a historical play: *Shakespeare's comedies, histories, and tragedies*.

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plural noun

1 [usu. treated as sing.] the activities associated with the governance of a country or area, especially the debate between parties having power: *the party quickly gained influence in French politics* | *thereafter he dropped out of active politics*.

• the activities of governments concerning the political relations between states: *in the conduct of global politics, economic status must be backed by military capacity*.

• the academic study of government and the state: [as modifier]: *a politics lecturer*.

• a particular set of political beliefs or principles: *people do not buy their paper purely for its politics*.

• (often the politics of) the principles relating to or inherent in a sphere or activity, especially when concerned with power and status: *the politics of gender*.

2 activities aimed at improving someone's status or increasing power within an organization, or a discussion of office politics and personalities.

‘True democracy is not just about having the right to vote.’ Do you agree?

Jiang Han 13S49

Since the birth of modern political theory more than two hundred years ago, democracy, with its high ideals of social contract, rule of law and separation of powers, as espoused by Enlightenment thinkers such as Voltaire and John Locke, has inspired many a generation of political leaders. In the contemporary era after the implosion of the Soviet Union, democracy seems to be on a relentless march towards universal acceptance. However, as recent popular revolutions in the Middle East have shown, too many people merely equate democracy with the right to vote, without attempting to establish concurrently the social foundations that make democracy truly a viable and efficacious system. I believe democracy is much more than just the right to vote, as the power of democratic vote cannot be sustained without other pillars of democracy such as the rule of law, civic engagement and political freedom.

Undoubtedly, the right to vote is a central tenet of democracy. In mature democratic nations, most of the national political life from electing governments to deciding on major national issues seems to revolve around the citizens' vote. One example is Switzerland. In the Alpine nation of eight million, people elect their government by direct democracy. Every Swiss citizen is entitled to vote on the choice of their government leaders as well as every bill that is debated in the Parliament. Allowing every citizen to express his views on government policies through direct voting thus represents the ultimate empowerment of the people and has become a distinctive feature of Swiss democracy. In other countries with larger populations, citizens' views are also solicited on major national issues through a referendum. A timely example could be the referendum scheduled on September 18th in the UK on Scottish independence. As both British and Scottish governments pre-emptively declared the results of the referendum to be binding, citizens thus became the ultimate decision-makers on such an issue of paramount importance to all those involved. Therefore, upon dissecting the political processes in major democracies, one can confidently say that citizens' vote is essential to sustain democracy and its legitimacy.

However, a casual observer should not thus conclude that democracy is only about giving citizens the vote. Such a superficial view masks the other vital elements of democracy that make the vote powerful. Chief among them is the rule of law. The rule of law ensures that free and fair elections will be held and the elected government will discharge their duties in strict accordance to the citizens' wish and mandate. Without the rule of law democracy rapidly loses its legitimacy as elections become rigged and people will lose faith in abiding by the system. The absence of this rule of law explains why many newly-democratic Middle Eastern and North African states such as Egypt and Tunisia, once much vaunted as the new beacons of hope after sweeping popular revolutions, have turned out to become spectacular political failures. In Egypt, parliamentary and presidential elections were held in 2012 which centred power on the Islamist Muslim Brotherhood. However, the notoriously belligerent Egyptian National Party did not recognise the results and proclaimed the elections to be rigged. Rampant protests and gratuitous violence soon gripped the country as people on both sides of the political spectrum, angered by what they perceived as a corrupt and unfair system, took to the streets. As this example demonstrates, the rule of law is a crucial pillar that sustains the legitimacy and power of the vote. Only the rule of law and consequent open and fair elections can ensure citizens' wishes are faithfully expressed through the voting results. Once this essential link breaks down, any election degenerates into nothing more than a political farce staged to confer semblances of legitimacy to an undemocratic government. Therefore, true democracy requires the rule of law for citizens' right to vote to be meaningful.

Furthermore, true democracy also requires political freedoms such as freedom of speech, freedom of assembly and the freedom to form new political parties. These civic liberties are not just corollary benefits of democracy but the essential fertile soil that nurtures democracy in the first place. In many undemocratic states such as China, citizens are also allowed to select the ruling political party through voting. However, such right to vote is meaningless as there is no viable political alternative to the ruling party. In China, any

media reports or even online comments that criticise the ruling Communist Party are severely censored. Outspoken critics of the government have been arrested and confrontational media outlets shut down. No new political parties can ever be formed in China as people are not permitted to assemble to protest or discuss political ideas. Such lack of political freedom severely curtails citizens' ability to acquire vital and unmasked information in making their political decisions. Presented with no credible alternatives and lacking in information regarding any wrongdoings of the government, many Chinese citizens blindly vote to keep the status quo. In stark contrast, Hong Kong citizens, long enjoying uncensored media and an entrenched right to protest, are now clamouring for the democratic vote to select their Chief Executive, despite no experience of wielding the vote. Hong Kong citizens' heightened awareness of their political freedoms and prerogatives has long fomented the desire for the right to vote. After being promised universal suffrage by Beijing since Hong Kong's handover to China, they are determined to make full democracy materialise in Hong Kong. Therefore, we can clearly see that the establishment and survival of democracy depends much less on the nominal right to vote than on the availability of political freedoms to citizens. True democracy is thus much more than just having the right to vote.

Last but not least, active civic engagement and education are also important enabling features of true democracy. Prima facie, democracy's legitimacy does not depend on having an engaged citizenry. However, it is an engaged and educated population that ultimately gives democracy its power and effectiveness. One forthcoming example is the United States where the citizens are generally politically active and informed, thanks to the tradition to assert individual rights and the presence of the media as a powerful watchdog. Therefore, American politicians feel added pressure to make judicious decisions lest their constituents vote them out. The general effectiveness of American democracy thus heavily depends on the supervision of active and informed citizens. We can contrast American's democracy with Japan's, where the citizens are much more politically apathetic and the media much less adversarial. Democracy there seems markedly less vibrant. Japan has suffered chronic economic mismanagement since the early 1990s. However, rotation of political parties is remarkably slow as the ruling Liberal Democratic Party has stayed in power almost uninterrupted for sixty years. Low turnout of voters at Japan's local and national elections also makes politicians feel secure in power. With the attendant complacency on the part of politicians, Japan's inactive democracy runs the risk of degenerating into a lumbering bureaucracy. Therefore, in order for democracy to stay vibrant and efficacious, engaging and informing citizens on the political level is of paramount importance. True democracy, hence, is not just about having the right to vote but about citizens actively exercising the right to vote.

In conclusion, it is easy for politicians and citizens alike to equate democracy with just the right to vote, its most salient feature. However, fundamentally democracy is about seeking collective wisdom of the population to govern the country and empowering each citizen to have a say in the destiny of their nation. Therefore, true democracy requires social foundations such as the rule of law, political liberties as well as civic engagement to be able to authentically represent, empower and consult the citizens on matters of national importance. Indeed, without the vote democracy would lose its most important avenue to solicit honest and informed opinions from the populations. However, without the enabling social foundations, democracy would be losing the source of these opinions altogether. How, then can we say true democracy is just about installing citizens' right to vote?

Teacher's comments: This is a fully relevant essay and ample materials were provided to lend scope and depth to your response. An excellent essay and a pleasure to read for its erudition. (Pity the China example, though; it marred an otherwise outstanding essay)

'True democracy is not just about having the right to vote.' Do you agree?

Wang Haochen 13S40

Democracy, as its Latin root *demos* suggests, literally means governance based on people. Undoubtedly, voting rights, the indispensable element underpinning this political system, are crucial for a successful democracy. Thus, it is tempting to conclude that the right to vote is a sufficient condition for democratic governance. In practice, however, a true democracy encompasses many other aspects as its solid foundation, among which are the rule of law, right of inquiry and free speech and the rights to hold political office. Absence of these cornerstones would very likely cast a political system into a virtual authoritarian regime covered by a facade of democratic righteousness. In this light, without the necessary supplements, voting rights alone are hardly sufficient for true democracy.

One has to acknowledge in the first place, that voting is an important guarantee for democracy to function. Ultimately, the opportunity for each citizen to voice his concerns and exercise his decisions must materialise into a concrete vote. It is through voting that the system of checks and balances are enabled and all political offices are properly assigned. In particular, a legally binding public referendum resolves many of the sensitive national affairs through the citizens' direct expression, enhancing the accountability of these major decisions. The upcoming Scottish referendum perfectly attests to the crucial role voting has assumed in a functioning democratic body. The national identity of the Scottish population may be redefined based on the results of their collective will and the referendum provides a peaceful channel for the parties of conflicting interests to settle the disputes. Given that the decision is only delivered by an unbiased public event, the impartiality of the process can thus be guaranteed. Similarly in Switzerland, citizens could directly participate in the legislation through petitions. Those garnering enough support within a hundred days of First Declaration Motive will be able to influence Parliament procedures through voting.

Repeatedly testified, voting rights are a peaceful and highly accountable channel through which the public could directly govern themselves. Any attempt at reducing the right to vote would simply render politics into a feudal dynastic authoritarian regime in which the vested interests dominate the political landscape.

Despite the testified wisdom that the right to vote is necessary to democracy, to conclude that the right to vote is sufficient for democracy is an argument worth deliberating. The most blatant contradiction to such a claim would be the one-party rule in China. Contrary to popular belief, each adult citizen above the age of 18 has the right to vote, and indeed the Chinese population has been voting ever since the establishment of the republic in 1949. Surprisingly, the resultant political landscape is far from ideal with an oppressive force controlling People's Congress with consistent majority seats. A more baffling panoply of such outright failures can be listed effortlessly: North Koreans do vote, Syrians under Assad do vote, Egyptians under Mubarak do vote. Voting, however, has not delivered its promised fruit, owing to the absence of other crucial elements.

The rule of law would be among the first and most important on those elements to be introduced. An independent judiciary system functions as a key supervising power over the execution of national affairs, including the voting process. It must not go unnoticed that in the above-mentioned cases, Switzerland and Scotland can carry out their referendum because a clearly defined and well-adhered legal standard is established in the first place. Without the legal backbone of public scrutiny and supervision, mass voting would deliver no peaceful resolutions but relentless chaos and turmoil. Such instances occur quite often in countries like the Philippines and Indonesia, where an ill-defined legal framework and corrupt judiciary branch altogether nullify the rule of law. The Philippine Aquino family has controlled the judiciary branch for nearly half a century, bribing ranks of judges and exploiting them to their political favor. Correspondingly, the Philippines' system is notorious for its blatant gerrymandering practices and in certain extreme cases, outrageous cheating by directly re-writing public votes in poll boxes. These distortions of democratic

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justice constantly remind us of the precarious isolation of voting from the rule of law, the very promise for successful voting in the first place.

A compounding factor that might endanger democracy is the lack of free speech and inquiry. Democracy, after all, is about granting all citizens the opportunities to express their will and influence governance in an enlightened manner. Free speech is thus a cornerstone safeguarding truly democratic governance. Again, in the most successful democratic bodies, free speech is upheld before any meaningful voting can take place at all. The United States Senate specifically declares that their bicameral legislation would pass no bills attempting at "silencing public dissent and expression on any grounds". Laudable efforts at silencing disagreement, as President Obama commented, would be expediently exploited to compromise democracy. As expected of such compromise, the Chinese democratic system, in which all dissent concerning political affairs is overly suppressed, fails to fulfill its purported mission of "democratic exercise shared among all, as stipulated in the Constitution". In an environment where propaganda restructures the entire media industry to a "patriotic" cause, the population will be collectively myopic towards this subtle erosion of their rights to vote, and when a certain authority instructs a community to vote for a particular figure whose public image has been fastidiously tailored and beautified, it is only natural that the public would obey and follow. The right to vote is baseless when the freedom of speech is stifled and people's eyes blindfolded.

Another prerequisite for democracy is the right to political office. A distinction has to be made that in this case the emphasis is on the political office of a regional level, drawing specific reference to the system of "to the winner goes the spoils". This is particularly seen in India whose democracy twisted the assignment of public office in such a way that regional governors are all appointed by a central body with majority votes. It should be noted that at a regional level, certain ethnic groups have special religious and racial concerns that should be represented by their own voice. A region with the majority being descendants yet the minority in power disrupts the balance of power.

In conclusion, democracy cannot possibly function without the right to vote, but the right to vote itself is in turn guaranteed and supplemented by other important factors such as the rule of law, right to free speech and inquiry and the right to public office for minority groups on a regional level. These founding pillars buttress successfully democratic governance. As the Chinese proverb goes, "one pillar cannot support a roof", the right to vote alone is far from the true concept of democracy.

Teacher's comments: A comprehensive and knowledgeable discussion about the limitations of voting in the face of an absence of certain principles of democracy. The keywords "having the right to vote" could be examined even more closely – consider the argument that voting is a basic right accorded to citizens even if they do not possess adequate knowledge about policies and the possible implications of adhering to those principles. Otherwise, this is a well-written response with a clear personal voice.

‘With increasing emphasis on rights, the state should not interfere in the private lives of its citizens.’ Discuss.

Seow Wei Liang 14A11

The recent uproar over the US government surveillance through its National Security Agency's PRISM programme has led to fierce debate about the legitimacy of state interfering in the private lives of its citizens. With citizens today becoming more cognisant and assertive of their rights, it is a perennial issue that all governments must confront. It is my conviction that the state should be allowed to interfere when the interests of society supersede an individual's rights. This can be seen in fulfilling state imperatives of maintaining social harmony, national security and economic well-being. However, any interference should only be legitimised with checks and balances in a larger democratic system of governance.

A compelling argument allowing for the state to intervene in the private lives of its citizens lies in the need to safeguard social harmony. While there have been greater calls for greater freedom of speech in democracies, these have not blunted the imperative that is social stability. For example, while Singapore has allowed freer discourse on both traditional and new media, it still remains underpinned by strict laws such as the Maintenance of Racial and Religious Harmony Act to prevent speeches threatening racial and religious harmony. While the state should enshrine ideals of free speech, such speech should not be without limits. The deleterious consequences were witnessed in the recent Charlie Hebdo attack where a French magazine corporation was attacked for its cartoon portraying the Prophet. While individuals should have the right to voice their opinions on a multitude of public platforms, the state should have the ability to limit this right if it impinges on the sensibilities of other members of society. Such an attitude would ensure the state is able to safeguard the rights of everyone in society while promoting more freedom for individuals.

The need to preserve national security is also another pertinent reason in allowing the interference to the private lives of individuals. The premise of rights is based on upon a secure state. Without it, citizens are unable to enjoy the freedom that they cherish. In fact, citizens already concede some rights to their privacy when they allow closed circuit televisions in their neighbourhoods for the greater public good of combatting crime. Similarly, even as citizens clamour for more privacy today, such demands cannot be disavowed from the reality of a more dangerous world today. Terror groups such as the Islamic State are transcending online platforms to radicalise individuals, as seen from the influx of European citizens fighting for their misguided jihadist quests. The emergence of individuals such as Jihadi John poses a pernicious threat to society as these citizens become enemies of the state. With more non-conventional threats in cyber-security and online warfare with terror groups, there is an even more urgent need to allow surveillance of the private lives of citizens. This empowers the state to pre-emptively isolate and diffuse any threats to our society at large. In exchange, it is only with a secure state can we continue protecting and enjoying more rights.

The state should also be allowed to interfere in the private lives of individuals to protect the economic welfare of the country and its citizens. With a more vocal and educated population, more citizens are rejecting a paternalistic government that interferes in their economic decisions. This is seen in Singapore with the popularisation of the slogan “Return Our CPF” on social media. However, in the context of a rapidly ageing population, more countries are directly mandating personal economic decisions. While the Singapore government has allowed more freedom in usage of the Central Provident Fund (CPF), the continuance of this scheme shows how such interference is key in ensuring Singapore's long-term economic sustainability where its citizens are self-sufficient. Even the US government which claims to be a bastion for freedom dictates the economic decision of its citizens and continues to implement unpopular initiatives such as Obamacare which mandates every citizen to purchase health insurance. As much as such actions attenuate an individual's free choice, they are justified so one can enjoy economic security and not be an economic burden to their society already struggling with acute economic challenges and constraints.

However, there are also legitimate concerns that such interference will lead to a slippery slope in eroding the rights of individuals. This devolves into an authoritarian state where individuals have no political voice. This is seen in countries such as North Korea where the government vociferously clamps down on its citizens through fear and repression. Thus, allowing unlimited interference would unleash a Pandora's box where governments would be allowed to interfere in all aspects of citizens' lives. This asymmetry in power would have detrimental effects, trampling upon basic human rights, and such is not ideal for the future society.

Another argument against interference is that the state will be able to systematically discriminate against minorities. Rights, such as the freedom of speech and religion are especially crucial to minorities in preventing subjugation by the majority. However, by allowing the state to interfere in private decisions, the minorities may be marginalized and their needs overlooked by the state. For example, the Rohingya Muslims are powerless against the Burman majority government in Myanmar who denies them even basic rights like citizenship or freedom to reproduce. Without rights to serve as an effective check and balance, minorities will be disenfranchised and excluded from political processes. This ultimately institutionalises discrimination and causes long-term injustice and inequality.

Despite the arguments above, the state should still be allowed to interfere in the private lives of citizens as long as there are sufficient and effectual checks and balances. Considering that multilateral international organisations such as the United Nations prizes the preservation of basic human rights as enshrined in the UN Declaration of Human Rights: any country that violates them would face repercussions on an international stage. Pariah states, such as North Korea and Syria, face sanctions due to their gross human right violations. Moreover, as seen from the 2011 'Arab Spring' uprisings, citizens would still rise up and protest interference in their private lives, should they perceive interference as unjust and undemocratic. With such effective mechanisms, any interference by the state would be carefully regulated.

In conclusion, there has been indeed an increase in emphasis on rights to address the asymmetry in power that the state has over its citizens. However, in the spirit of the government's duty of ensuring social harmony, national security and economic welfare, interference, coupled with checks and balances is still justified and should be allowed.

Teacher's comments: Various points raised and discussed. Apt use of supporting evidence. However, do take note of your link back to the question at the end of each paragraph. A decent attempt.

The American publisher Larry Flynt once said that "Majority rule only works if you're considering individual rights, because you can't have five wolves and one sheep voting on what to have for supper." In today's world where the vast majority of countries have adopted some form of democracy, it is often the majority in the country whose views are heard and this could easily lead to suppression of minority views and the tyranny of the majority. Indeed, this is often detrimental to the political and social stability of the country, especially when the minority groups attempt to fight for their rights, for they too are citizens and entitled to good governance that takes their perspectives into consideration. However, defending the rights of the minorities may come at a price, and it is thus the prerogative of the government to assess whether the country is able to pay that price, as not all minority rights can or should be protected.

Protecting minority rights in some circumstances may not be worth the cost and hence should be forgone for the greater good. In the first place, the definition of what constitutes a "right" can be hazy and subjective. Depending on the political system and government, certain rights may not be agreed on and hence governments should take a stand on what they consider to be rights accorded to every citizen and not simply be wavered by every demand from minority groups. Mill's Harm Principle could be used as a guide as well. If what minorities claim as a right is detrimental to another person or to the majority, then despite social disorder that may arise from denial of their rights, the government ought not to protect these minority rights for the sake of overall benefit to the people as a whole. For instance, countries like Austria and Singapore have banned smoking in public places, in what could be seen by the minority who smoke as a denial of their right to make choices. However, since inhalation of second-hand smoke has been proven to have adverse health effects on a person, for the sake of greater benefit to non-smokers who make up the majority, it is justifiable for the government to not incur the health cost to the population simply for the sake of protecting minority rights. Since the social contract compels the government to provide security for the people, it is only right that they consider the big picture and act in the interests of the majority in such cases. Hence, the cost of protecting minority rights must be carefully considered, as well as the context, as some countries may not be able or obliged to bear the costs.

However, there are certain basic human rights that should not be violated, if not for any other reason than moral principle. For example, the right to live, think freely, move, et cetera, though of course there are exceptions such as the death penalty for criminals. Just recently, many Rohingya Muslims were stranded at sea after they were abandoned by human traffickers. To delve deeper into the issue, they were stranded not just because of the human traffickers, but the fact that they were an unrecognised group in Myanmar where they claimed to have lived for generations. With successive Myanmar governments introducing policies to suppress them, most recently the removal of their right to vote by declaring their temporary registration certificates invalid, the Rohingyas attempted to enter other countries in search of better lives. Perhaps, the cost of protecting the Rohingyas' rights to live and make a living in Myanmar were seen by the government and some of the Burmese as a dilution of their racial and religious composition, or a burden to their still-developing economy. However, since they are living within the country's borders and cannot be proven to have illegally migrated until only recently, the Myanmar government could be said to have a moral imperative to protect their rights as humans. Yet, it chose not to sacrifice votes and nationalism to do so. Eventually, many of these Rohingyas were forced to leave and many ended up found dead in gruesome mass graves that were discovered in Thailand and Malaysia. Thus, when it comes to unalienable human rights, the material costs of defending these rights should not be seen as greater than the unseen cost to the human conscience of denying these rights; rather they should be protected as far as possible.

The answer to the question of whether to protect minority rights also becomes more obvious when the minority is a significant one, one whose voice can be clearly heard and has been heard for a long time. In Malaysia, where the United Malays National Organisation (UMNO), helmed by the Barisan Nasional

